

History of Bangladesh(1757-1971)

I. The Fall of Sovereignty: The Battle of Plassey (1757)

The year 1757 serves as the definitive turning point in South Asian history.

- **The Conflict:** Relations between **Nawab Siraj-ud-Daulah** of Bengal and the British East India Company (EIC) soured over the British misuse of trade privileges and the fortification of Fort William in Calcutta.
- **The Betrayal:** On June 23, 1757, at the Palashi (Plassey) woods, the Nawab's forces were defeated, largely due to the conspiracy of his commander-in-chief, **Mir Jafar**, and the financier Jagat Seth, who sided with **Robert Clive**.
- **The Aftermath:** This victory gave the EIC effective control over the Bengal treasury. It wasn't just a battle; it was the "Great Plunder" of Bengal that financed the Industrial Revolution in Britain.

II. The Grant of Diwani and the Great Famine (1765–1770)

In 1765, following the Battle of Buxar, the Mughal Emperor was forced to grant the EIC the **Diwani Rights**—the right to collect land revenue in Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa.

- **Dual Government:** The British collected the money, while the Nawab held the responsibility for administration (with no funds). This systemic corruption led to the **Great Famine of 1770**, where an estimated one-third of Bengal's population (10 million people) perished while the Company continued to enforce high tax collection.

III. Economic Transformation and the Permanent Settlement (1793)

Under **Lord Cornwallis**, the British introduced the **Permanent Settlement Act of 1793**.

- **The Zamindari System:** This created a new class of hereditary landlords (Zamindars) who owned the land as long as they paid a fixed revenue to the British.
- **Social Impact:** The traditional peasantry (ryots) lost their rights to the land and were often exploited. This created a socioeconomic divide that persisted for over a century, as many of the new landlords were city-dwelling elites, while the rural cultivators remained impoverished.
- **De-industrialization:** The British systematically dismantled Bengal's world-famous textile industry (muslin) to favor machine-made goods from Manchester, turning Bengal into a raw-material-producing colony.

IV. The Resistance Movements (1800s)

As colonial pressure mounted, several religious and peasant-led movements emerged to challenge British and Zamindar authority:

- **Faraizi Movement (1818):** Founded by **Haji Shariatullah**, it began as a religious reform but evolved into a peasant uprising against the oppression of indigo planters and landlords. His son, **Dudu Miyan**, later organized the peasants into a more militant force.
- **The Indigo Revolt (1859):** Bengali farmers were forced to grow indigo (a blue dye) instead of food crops under brutal conditions. The "Blue Mutiny" eventually forced the British to appoint an Indigo Commission and scale back the forced cultivation.
- **Titu Mir's Rebellion (1831):** Syed Mir Nisar Ali (Titu Mir) built a famous "Bamboo Fort" (Bansher Kella) in Narkelberia to resist British tax collectors. Though he fell in battle, he became a symbol of early Bengali resistance.

V. The Bengal Renaissance and Educational Shift

During the 19th century, Bengal underwent an intellectual awakening known as the **Bengal Renaissance**.

- **Intellectual Leaders:** Figures like **Raja Ram Mohan Roy** and **Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar** pushed for social reform (abolition of Sati, widow remarriage) and modern Western education.
- **The Birth of Nationalism:** The establishment of Calcutta University in 1857 and the formation of the Indian National Congress in 1885 saw the rise of a new "Bhadralok" (gentleman) class. However, the Muslim community in Bengal initially lagged behind in English education, a gap that leaders like **Nawab Abdul Latif** and **Syed Ameer Ali** worked to close by founding educational societies.

VI. The First Partition of Bengal (1905–1911)

The roots of Bangladeshi identity can be traced back to the British administrative decision in 1905. Under **Lord Curzon**, the British Empire divided the Bengal Presidency into two: **West Bengal** and **Eastern Bengal & Assam**.

- **The Muslim Perspective:** For the Muslims of Eastern Bengal, the partition was welcomed. It promised better education, administrative focus, and economic growth for a region that had long been neglected by the capital in Calcutta.
- **The Nationalist Backlash:** The Hindu elite and Indian nationalists saw the partition as a "divide and rule" tactic. This sparked the **Swadeshi Movement**, leading to widespread protests and boycotts of British goods.
- **The Annulment (1911):** Due to intense political pressure and unrest, the British reunited Bengal in 1911. This reversal left many Bengali Muslims feeling betrayed by the British and

wary of the Indian National Congress, eventually fueling the desire for a separate Muslim homeland.

VII. The Pakistan Movement and Partition (1940–1947)

In 1940, the **Lahore Resolution** (initially proposing independent "states" in the East and West) set the stage for the creation of Pakistan. When the British left in 1947, the subcontinent was partitioned into India and Pakistan.

- **A Divided Nation:** Pakistan was a geographical anomaly, consisting of two wings—**West Pakistan** and **East Bengal** (later East Pakistan)—separated by over 1,000 miles of Indian territory.
- **Early Grievances:** While united by religion, the two wings were divided by language, culture, and economy. From the outset, the center of power remained in the West, leading to immediate feelings of marginalization in the East.

VIII. The Language Movement (1948–1952)

The first major crack in the unity of Pakistan appeared when the government attempted to impose **Urdu** as the sole state language, despite the fact that the majority of the population (in the East) spoke **Bengali**.

- **The Spark:** On February 21, 1952 (**Amar Ekushey**), students at Dhaka University defied a ban on public gatherings (Section 144) to protest for their mother tongue.
- **The Massacre:** Police opened fire, killing protesters including **Salam, Barkat, Rafiq, and Jabbar**.
- **Impact:** This sacrifice turned a linguistic demand into a nationalistic struggle. It proved that religious unity was not enough to bridge the cultural gap between the two wings. Bengali was eventually recognized as a state language in 1956.

IX. Political and Economic Disparity (1954–1966)

Throughout the 1950s and 60s, East Pakistan was treated as a "colony" for the West.

- **Economic Drain:** While the East produced the majority of the country's foreign exchange (through jute exports), the bulk of national development funds were spent in the West.
- **The United Front (1954):** In provincial elections, a coalition of Bengali parties (The United Front) crushed the Muslim League, signaling the East's desire for self-rule. However, the central government soon dismissed this elected body.
- **Military Rule:** The rise of **General Ayub Khan** in 1958 further centralized power, stripping

Bengalis of their political voice.

X. The Six-Point Movement and the 1969 Uprising

In 1966, **Sheikh Mujibur Rahman**, leader of the Awami League, presented the **Six-Point Program**. It was a charter for regional autonomy, demanding:

1. A federal form of government.
2. Defense and Foreign Affairs only at the center.
3. Separate currencies or strict fiscal controls.
4. Power of taxation at the provincial level.
5. Separate accounts for foreign exchange.
6. The setting up of a militia for East Pakistan.

The West Pakistani regime responded by arresting Mujib and launching the **Agartala Conspiracy Case** (1968), accusing him of treason. This backfired, triggering a massive **1969 Mass Uprising** that forced Ayub Khan to resign and release Mujib.

XII. The 1970 Election and the Crisis

In the first-ever general elections of Pakistan in 1970, the **Awami League** won a landslide victory, securing 167 out of 169 seats in East Pakistan—giving them an absolute majority in the National Assembly.

- **The Refusal:** The military junta, led by **Yahya Khan**, and West Pakistani leaders (Zulfikar Ali Bhutto) refused to hand over power.
- **The 7th March Speech:** On March 7, 1971, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman delivered his historic speech at the Racecourse Ground, declaring: *"The struggle this time is for our freedom. The struggle this time is for our independence!"*

XIII. The Liberation War (March – December 1971)

- **Operation Searchlight (March 25):** The Pakistan Army launched a brutal midnight crackdown, targeting students, intellectuals, and civilians. Sheikh Mujib was arrested after declaring independence in the early hours of March 26.
- **The Resistance:** The **Mukti Bahini** (Freedom Fighters), composed of students, peasants, and defecting soldiers, began a guerrilla war. A government-in-exile was formed in **Mujibnagar** on April 17.
- **The Genocide:** Over the next nine months, an estimated 3 million people were killed, and

10 million refugees fled to India.

- **The Final Victory:** In December 1971, India joined the conflict. The joint command of the Mukti Bahini and Indian Armed Forces forced the Pakistan Army to surrender.
- **Victory Day:** On **December 16, 1971**, 93,000 Pakistani troops surrendered at Dhaka, and **Bangladesh** emerged as a sovereign, independent nation.